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1 Social Construction in Communication

Re-Constituting the Conversation

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In this chapter, we offer a response to Shotter and Gergen's (1994) proposal in *Communication Yearbook* for social construction (SC) as a framework for communication by reconstituting its impact in our field. We provide an overview of SC research in the communication discipline to illustrate the ways in which scholars have developed specifically communication-oriented SC approaches. After wresting SC from the realm of epistemology and placing it into that of practical theory, we select three areas of research and praxis where social constructionist thinking about communication makes a dramatic difference in thinking and practice. These areas—gender, crisis, and therapy—allow us to move beyond the confines of an American academic forum and engage the concerns of an audience of practitioners in a more global exchange. Additionally, these three topics give us the opportunity to address relevant and still pressing critiques that we take to be consequential to both SC and communication: materiality, agency, and critical applications of practical theory that allow social construction scholars to speak politically on matters heretofore considered extradiscursive. A section on future directions for and challenges to social constructionism concludes our reflection.

In their 1994 *Communication Yearbook* chapter, psychologists John Shotter and Kenneth Gergen rejoined an ongoing exchange about SC (P. L. Berger & Luckmann, 1966; Gergen, 1985; Gilbert & Mulkay, 1984; Goolishian & Anderson, 2002; McNamee & Gergen, 1999; Potter & Wetherell, 1987; Shotter & Gergen, 1989, among others), staking a claim to its paradigmatic vision as a framework for communication. Delineating the merits of a conversational epistemology and arguing for the centrality of conversation as both a site

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and a generative metaphor for communication study, the authors pressed for a relational, situated, and reflexive space for communication research. As a rejoinder to Shotter & Gergen (1994), this review of SC in communication itself comprises a conversational move: an act of and into communication (W. B. Pearce, 1994) from a particular positioning and, by its very performance, strategic (Bernstein, 1992).

The timing for our rejoinder seems right. Our desire to write this chapter partially results from a strong, resurgent interest of SC in the discipline as evidenced through the Summer Institute "Catching Ourselves in the Act" sponsored in the summer of 2006 by the National Communication Association (NCA; see Galanes & Leeds-Hurwitz, forthcoming) and the ensuing formation of the Social Construction Division in the NCA. As academics who were graduate students in the 1990s and, as scholars of language and social interaction, we were raised conversant in the language of SC and identify with its sentiment and research praxis. In our exchanges with other scholars, we remark how ideas about the narrative construction of identity and the constructed nature of gender, problems, and even our own relationships have settled as curricular dust that seems neither worthy of stirring nor cleaning up. Yet, like Edwards, Ashmore, and Potter (1995), we find that others continue to express misgivings about rampant relativism and implied moral turpitude that begin with furniture thumping (the reality of furniture cannot be denied!) and ultimately equate SC with an immaterial (Penman, 2000) and inconsequential (Sigman, 1995) view of communication. However, social constructionism offers little critical reflection of its own presence on the academic stage, appearing as a magically driven enterprise, "an image more consistent with the scientism it sought to overthrow" (Stam, 2001, p. 295).

We choose this forum to rejoin Shotter and Gergen's (1994) conversational proposal by taking their contribution as a marker in time and asking how we can appreciate its impact within the discipline in terms of creating spaces for new vocabularies, research practices, theoretical applications, and challenges. Our move is aligned with Craig's (1999) outline for a metadiscursive appreciation of communication as composed of a set of self-contained, yet dialectically coherent traditions, each with its taken-for-granted assumptions, inner complexity, and practical outcomes. In turn, we understand and evaluate SC in communication not as a theory but as a metatheoretical position and aim not for deconstruction but for reconstruction and reconstitution, in the spirit of searching for possibility.

Our review chapter unfolds as follows. Recognizing the constructed nature of SC (Bernstein, 1992; W. B. Pearce, 1995; Potter, 1996), we begin by providing an overview of communication SC approaches to illustrate the ways in which scholars have developed a specifically communication-oriented SC thinking. Wresting SC from the realm of epistemology and placing it into that of practical theory (Cronen, 1995b), which allows us, in Wittgenstein's sense, to create the knowledge of "how to go on" (1980, p. 875), we then select

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three areas of research and praxis where social constructionist thinking about communication makes a dramatic difference in thinking and practice. A section on future directions for and challenges to social constructionism concludes our chapter.

SOCIAL CONSTRUCTION IN COMMUNICATION: A REVIEW OF THE LITERATURE[1]

A key word search for "social constructionism" in the Communication and Mass Media Index database yielded only 86 references, with the broader search term of "social construction" yielding 213 references. While promising, these numbers pale in comparison to the overall research output in the discipline. Thus, we felt that this first view belied a more complex picture of the status of SC in communication. Indeed, the ongoing interest in SC in the field, as evidenced by the 2006 NCA Summer Institute, the new NCA Social Construction Division, and the ease with which communication scholars acknowledge the influence of social constructionism in their work, attests to the position of SC in the communication discipline.

In this section, we argue that a vibrant SC program in communication exists—one that has reconstituted SC as a specifically communication process. We refer to this enterprise as communication social construction (CSC) to distinguish it from the development of SC in other fields.

Craig (1999) noted that many theories of communication are "borrowed from other disciplines" (p. 123). For example, the very phrase "social construction" comes from P. L. Berger and Luckmann's (1966) sociological treatise, while probably the most recognized social constructionist, Kenneth J. Gergen, primarily addressed psychology (Gergen, 1985, 1991, 1994, 1998, 1999, 2001). Our review focuses on interdiscursive connections—the specific nuances with which researchers have adapted, built on and refined SC ideas from a communication perspective. Inspired by Craig's metamodel of communication theories, we address the following three questions:

1. What is the metadiscursive vocabulary for describing and applying CSC?
2. What are specific CSC approaches?
3. How has CSC research addressed the issues of materiality, agency, and consequentiality?

Metadiscursive vocabulary constitutes terminology related to communication (Craig, 1999). We identify the terms that CSC researchers utilize to describe and apply a SC perspective. As Leeds-Hurwitz (forthcoming) noted, a great deal of CSC research is implicitly rather than explicitly identified as such (i.e., scholars apply the metatheoretical framework afforded by social constructionism, but they do not necessarily invoke the specific term "social

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construction"). In posing our first question, we wish to underscore the alternative ways that communication scholars employ to describe SC.

For our second question, rather than ask what SC thinking has done for communication, we reverse the relationship and emphasize what communication has contributed to understanding SC processes. Hence, we selectively identify and describe communication theories and approaches that are social constructionist or draw from this tradition.

Finally, we provide a commentary on three areas of CSC research—gender, therapy, and crisis—to illustrate how contemporary CSC work has addressed the problematics of materiality, agency, and consequentiality that have typically been used to level critiques against SC.

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Metadiscursive Vocabulary

Four vocabularies frame SC research: (1) *interpretive* approaches, (2) *social approaches*, (3) a *constitutive* perspective, and (4) *construction* with modifiers. Our selection of order is approximately chronological. As we discuss each variation, we also note cautions in the application of this vocabulary to understanding CSC.

Interpretive Approaches

The term *interpretive approaches* became popular with Putnam and Pacanowsky (1983). As a counter to the dominant functionalist perspectives of organizational communication that treat communication in an instrumental fashion (i.e., as a "tool" to understand more significant phenomena), "interpretivists believe that reality is *socially constructed* through the words, symbols, and behaviors of its members" (emphasis added, Putnam, 1983, p. 35). Putnam further elaborated that an interpretive perspective focuses on symbolic processes and a pluralistic approach.

Though scholars widely use interpretive approaches in communication, Cheney (2000) is critical of how the use of the term *interpretive* mystifies more than it reveals. Cheney's own interpretation of "interpretive" identified strategies of allegiance (against functionalists), methodological identification ("a simplistic synonym for qualitative data analysis"), and deflection within a conversation ("never having to explain your methodology," p. 25; see also Hacking, 1999).

Social Approaches

Explicitly drawing a parallel to Putnam and Pacanowsky's (1983) introduction of interpretive approaches to organizational communication, Leeds-Hurwitz (1995) introduced *social approaches* as an alternative to social scientific approaches to the study of interpersonal communication. In contrast to an "objectivist" position, social approaches are methodologically interpretive and

focus on the dynamics of interpersonal communication (e.g., Baxter, 2004; Baxter & Montgomery, 1996; Varey, 2000). Though several differences exist across social approaches, Leeds-Hurwitz identified 11 themes: (1) a focus on the social rather than cognitive, (2) communication as process as well as product, (3) a social construction of reality perspective, (4) the creation of social meanings, (5) identity as socially constructed, (6) culture, (7) the significance of context, (8) the use of direct observation in research, (9) symbols, (10) reflexivity in research, and (11) a holistic approach. Examples of social approaches that Leeds-Hurwitz specified include discourse analysis, ethnography of communication, ethnomethodology, conversation analysis, pragmatics, coordinated management of meaning, symbolic interactionism, cultural studies, critical theory, and narrative analysis, to name a few.

Lucaites and Fitch (1997) cautioned that the rubric "social approaches" risks collapsing important differences between the specific approaches. In this respect, we must consider the differences among social approaches that W. B. Pearce (1995) outlined at a metatheoretical level, notably seeking certainty versus exercising "curiosity," a monadic versus pluralistic view of the world, and a representational versus practical view of knowledge. Though communication scholars do not widely utilize the term *social approaches*, the more specific approaches described within this area have been applied regularly in research, most notably in language and social interaction (see Fitch & Sanders, 2005).

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Constitutive Perspective

The term *constitutive* has rippled throughout conversations of communication (e.g., Dixon, 2000; Goldsmith & Baxter, 1996; Mumby, 1989; Mumby & Stohl, 1996; Trethewey, 2000), with Deetz (1994) providing one of the most explicit articulations of this perspective and its connection to social construction (see also Stewart, 1995). Standing for the place of communication as a mode of explanation, "constitutive" evokes a reflexive relationship between theory and culture as well as Deetz's stake for a disciplinary effort to reconstruct practices of deliberation, democracy, and negotiation (see also Craig, 1999). Deetz's articulation of a constitutive view of communication is an ontological one. Deetz explained:

> *If we are to make our full social contribution, we have to move from studying 'communication' phenomena as formed and explained psychologically, sociologically, and economically, and produce studies that study psychological, sociological, and economic phenomena as formed and explained communicationally*. (p. 568; emphasis in original)

How to understand communication as constitutive is still under exploration, particularly in the field of organizational communication (e.g., Dixon, 2000).

Some areas of research include the relationship between discourse and organizing (Fairhurst & Putnam, 2004), identity (S. J. Tracy & Trethewey, 2005), messages (McPhee & Zaug, 2000), embodiment (Trethewey, 2000), and resistance (Mumby, 2005).

Construction with Modifiers

Rather than SC, several projects have used variations such as *discursive construction, co-construction, joint construction,* and *joint action*. For example, some studies examined discursive constructions in organizations (Fairhurst & Putnam, 2004), problems (Buttny, 1996, 2004), information (Terranova, 2006), and gender in interpersonal (Pienaar & Bekker, 2006) as well as organizational contexts (Ashcraft & Mumby, 2004b; Buzzanell & Liu, 2005). Others coined the term *co-construction* (e.g., Jacoby & Ochs, 1995; McVittie, 2004), and some described joint construction (e.g., Georgakopoulou, 2002). Authors who employed the terminology of joint action include Cronen (1995a) in detailing the coordinated management of meaning perspective, and Castor (2005), Shotter (2005), and Holman and Thorpe (2003) in explicating SC processes in organizational contexts.

The variations on construction underline the importance of language in the case of discursive construction and the salience of interaction in the cases of co-construction, joint construction, and joint action. These variations highlight how "construction" modified by "social" does not necessarily offer the key way to capture an SC approach in communication. Instead, researchers emphasize the linguistic and interactive aspects of SC processes. To identify social constructionist research in communication, one must go beyond the specific term of *social construction* and evaluate research by how it furthers SC's metatheoretical possibilities, rather than paying lip service to its terminology.

Communication Social Construction Approaches

Many approaches have influenced CSC research such as the dramaturgical approach (e.g., Goffman, 1959), ethnomethodology (e.g., Garfinkel, 1967), poststructuralism (e.g., Foucault, 1980), philosophy of language (e.g., Wittgenstein, 1953), literacy criticism (e.g., Bakhtin, 1981, 1984, 1986; Volosinov, 1986) and others (e.g., Vygotsky, 1986). Several communication approaches advance an SC perspective. Some are explicitly social constructionist; whereas, others hold SC assumptions but do not necessarily emphasize SC as a primary frame. We present four approaches that provide a specifically communication perspective on SC[2] and that were selected according to their emphasis on a practical, relational, and/or questioning perspective of communication and social construction. In this section, we emphasize the coordinated management of meaning, relationally-responsive social constructionism, action-implicative discourse analysis, and dialogic

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approaches. As we examine each orientation to research, we explain why we chose it for inclusion, review its key assumptions, describe example studies, and specify contributions of each to understanding the relationship between communication and SC.

Coordinated Management of Meaning

W. B. Pearce and Cronen (W. B. Pearce, 1976, 1989; W. B. Pearce & Cronen, 1980; Philipsen, 1995) developed the coordinated management of meaning (CMM), initially known as a "rules" approach (Berger, 2005; Pearce, 1976), in the late 1970s and early 1980s. CMM has undergone a great deal of development and transformation. According to Barge and W. B. Pearce (2004, p. 25), "Its evolution can be charted in several ways: from purely academic to thoroughly integrated in various sorts of practice; from scientific to social constructionist/pragmatic; and from explanatory/predictive to a practical theory." CMM has progressed from an interpretive theory to one with a critical edge and, currently, a practical theory (W. B. Pearce, 2004). This theory also has been identified as a communication theory influenced by social construction (e.g., Barge & Pearce, 2004; Dillon & Galanes, 2002; Griffin, 2006).

Shailor (1997) argued that "[t]he basic premise of CMM is that our social realities are continually created, maintained and transformed in a reflexive process of action and interpretation" (p. 97). Because CMM constitutes a very broad and "ambitious" (Philipsen, 1995, p. 14) theory and research program, we address only four of its key concepts: *persons in conversation*, *the hierarchy of meaning*, *rules*, and *loops*. Persons in conversation constitutes the primary unit of observation in CMM (Cronen, 1995a). This idea foregrounds interaction in the construction of social reality and the ongoing negotiation of meaning in conversation. In the CMM perspective, interlocutors construct meaning through their stories, which themselves exist within the context of episodes. Conversational partners may point to one level among a multilevel hierarchy of contexts, such as episodes, relationships, identity, and culture (W. B. Pearce, 2004). Also, as Shailor emphasized, "contexts are not found things, but are interpretive achievements" (p. 97).

Rules were a key aspect of initial articulations of CMM (C. R. Berger, 2005; W. B. Pearce, 1976). CMM identifies two types of rules: *regulative* and *constitutive*. Regulative rules direct actions by specifying what kind of behavior should or should not occur. Constitutive rules serve as guides for interpretation. A *loop* refers to a cycle of interaction and how interlocutors respond to each other. Loops may be charmed, subversive, or strange—which terms refer, respectively, to when levels of meaning in the hierarchy are consistent with each other, when levels of meaning differ (perhaps irreparably so), and when a change of level entails a shift in meaning.

Barge and W. B. Pearce (2004) described five research "streams" in CMM: interpersonal and intercultural communication; organizational communication

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and management; public communication; therapy and consultation, and conflict, mediation, and dialogue.[3] For example, Shailor (1994) analyzed transcripts and video recordings of dispute mediation sessions and identified how mediators who tended to use a "problem-solving approach" were less successful in helping the disputants and even worsened the problems in some cases. Alternatively, mediators who utilized approaches that were similar to some of the key ideas in CMM tended to be more successful in assisting clients. Shailor's analysis applied CMM by examining the kinds of communication occurring in relation to the CMM model and the interrelationship of communication with disputants' abilities to coordinate their meanings. In a cultural and health context, Bruss et al. (2005) applied CMM to understanding childhood obesity in the Commonwealth of the Northern Mariana Islands. Also, Bruss et al. focused on what acceptable eating habits meant for the community of focus to understand cultural assumptions related to health. As with Shailor's project, Bruss et al. had a practical orientation in trying to understand how to bring about social change.

As a social constructionist approach that draws from American pragmatists such as James and Dewey (Barge, 2004; Cronen, 1995a; W. B. Pearce, 2004; Shailor, 1997), CMM addresses communication practices and their moral implications. Thus, CMM takes a "realistic" position with regard to ontology, in contrast to an objectivist or relativist stance. Key to this orientation, as Cronen explained, is the notion of being able to "go on"—for which a response must enable a next step. Cronen provided the example of someone trying to test a theory of bouncing a bag of potato chips—the world will not respond in a way to enable such a theory. If theories have (moral) careers, then it is interesting to note how CMM was one of the first to be explicitly characterized as social constructionist, while gradually evolving to align with the realistic-ontological and practical voices in social construction.

Relationally Responsive Social Constructionism

"To understand human communication better," wrote Shotter (2000a), "we do not need any new theories. We need to elaborate critically the spontaneous theory of language we already possess" (p. 129). Set against Shotter's (1999) progressive disaffection with "the way of theory" in communication as a belief in unifying principles, the relationally responsive social constructionist perspective (Cunliffe, 2002; Shotter, 1993, 1998, 2000b, 2004, 2005) weaves together the work of various scholars, including Bakhtin, Garfinkel, Vico, Volosinov, Vygotsky, and Wittgenstein.[4] Because Shotter (1993) resisted the characterization of theory, he referred to his work as providing a "critical tool box" of sensitizing concepts for researchers to apply (p. 206). Here, we describe his "tools" of joint actions, persons-in-conversation, responsiveness, and unique events.

Like CMM, the relationally responsive approach describes social construction as based on the joint actions of persons-in-conversation. Shotter's (1993) conversational world is one of unintended consequences, not fully explainable

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processes, and unpredictable outcomes. As Shotter (2005) explained, "for, whether we like it or not, the fact is that we are always 'entangled' or 'entwined' in a ceaseless flow of relational background activity going on between ourselves and the realities of the others and othernesses around us" (p. 114).

Drawing from Bakhtin, Shotter (1993) desired to capture the unselfconscious presence of human beings in spontaneous interaction with each other. According to Shotter, the idea of responsiveness relates to the enablements and constraints of communication in social accountability where people's words and actions are intelligible within an already specified interactional context of moral implications and answerability. Shotter's recent work on Bakhtinian "once-occurrent events of Being" develops responsiveness away from "theory" toward a Wittgensteinan notion of "social poetics" (see, for e.g., Shotter, 2000b). Like the "dialogical moments" recognized by Martin Buber and Carl Rogers (as we detail later in this chapter), once-occurrent events comprise unique, unfinished moments of connection in communication that render possible other connections, in unique and unexpected ways. For example, Shotter and Katz's (1998) discussion of the work of therapist Tom Andersen focused on his ability to transcend notions of therapy as change—born of theories and of reframes—by acting within fleeting aspects of a conversation to create new openings for practical re-direction.

In addition to Katz and Shotter's work in therapeutic settings (1996; see also Shotter & Katz, 1998), the relationally responsive approach has been utilized to understand interactions involving reported speech (Buttny, 2004) and accounts (Castor, 2005; Shotter, 1984). More recent discussions of relationally responsive social constructionism have addressed organizational contexts (e.g., Castor, 2005; Cunliffe, 2001, 2002; Holman & Thorpe, 2003; Shotter, 1998, 2004, 2005, 2006).

The relationally responsive approach highlights SC as a relational process. As such, this approach privileges understanding communication phenomena (i.e., accounts, reported speech) in actual, moment-to-moment interactions in which interlocutors are accountable to a past, present, anticipated future, and each other. In this respect, the relationally responsive approach contributes to an understanding of CSC as practical and relational.

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Action-implicative Discourse Analysis

Blending various interaction-centered approaches, AIDA (Action-implicative Discourse Analysis) is based on Craig and K. Tracy's (1995) explication of grounded practical theory and focuses on the interconnection between theory and practice, or how practice can inform and shape theory. AIDA argues for the interconnection of three levels of analysis—communication practice, problems, and situated ideals. By using problems as a nexus, researchers applying AIDA seek to describe the communication practices that function to shape problems and the situated ideals of participants as discerned through problem analysis.

Adopting grounded practical theory (see Craig & K. Tracy, 1995) as a metatheoretical perspective, AIDA constitutes a *normative* approach. Its analysis draws from participants' descriptions to make explicit their situated ideals for communication practices. In situating knowledge in the practice of communication and viewing discursive construction as constitutive and consequential, AIDA works to describe what *should be* as opposed to the "what-is" descriptions of empiricist discourse approaches (K. Tracy, 1995, p. 196).

AIDA concentrates on problems because it permits exploration of challenging situations that participants most likely reflect on and make explicit their expectations of what should be. Craig and K. Tracy (1995) explained that "[a] working assumption of our model is that communication problems typically arise because communicators pursue multiple, competing goals or purposes such that conflicts among goals often emerge to block ongoing discourse and require reflective thinking" (p. 254).

Craig and K. Tracy (1995) elaborated on the following three levels of analysis for AIDA:

1. *The technical level:* At the most concrete level, a practice can be reconstructed as a repertory of specific communicative strategies and techniques that are routinely available to be employed within the practice. (p. 253)
2. *The problem level:* Intrinsic to every practice are certain problems or dilemmas that affect the use of specific techniques. (p. 253)
3. *The philosophical level:* At the most abstract level, a practice can be reconstructed in the form of elaborated normative ideals and overarching principles that provide a rationale for the resolution of problems…A practice can thus be reconstructed by articulating these situated ideals as explicit philosophical positions. (pp. 253-254)

Each of these levels pinpoints different foci for description and analysis. The foci at the technical level are concrete communication activities. For example, Craig and K. Tracy described the providing of background information and question formulations as technical moves. For this level, K. Tracy (1995) advocated the use of naturally occurring discourse data to identify the repertory of communication practices utilized by social actors. This level, in particular, reflects the discourse analytic roots of AIDA in examining naturally occurring communicative interactions with attention to the interconnection between language use and context.

At the problem level, questions such as "What are the problems actors see as they seek to communicate appropriately? What concerns do actors themselves have?" guide analysis (Craig & K. Tracy, 1995, p. 255). For example, in detailing the problems that participants encounter during academic intellectual discussions, K. Tracy (1995) described the competing goals of idea development

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and building community (see also K. Tracy & Baratz, 1993). Craig and K. Tracy also positioned the level of problems as central to their approach in that this level implicates the level below (the technical level) and the level above (the philosophical level) in terms of abstraction. The problem level functions as a nexus for understanding the interconnection between micro-practices, in the forms of interactions and specific communication actions, and the macro-level, in the form of generalizeable, situated ideals. Craig and K. Tracy also referred to this latter level as the philosophical level.

At the philosophical level, researchers reconceptualize a practice in terms of the ideals that participants have for that practice or, as Craig and K. Tracy (1995) suggested, the "theoretical reconstruction" or "rational reconstruction" (p. 252) of a practice. The ideals formulated through rational reconstruction go beyond the immediate situation (e.g., a school board policy debate; K. Tracy & Ashcraft, 2001) and contribute to a more general normative theory (i.e., the understanding of how large groups manage dilemmas). Emphasizing the mutual interplay between theory and practice, Craig and K. Tracy explained:

> The ultimate test of such a practical theory is not, then, like scientific theory, its capacity to explain an existing reality but rather its usefulness for practice and reflection. The underlying philosophy is not realism (theory describes the world) or idealism (theory constitutes the world) but rather a reflective pragmatism (theory informs praxis). (p. 252)

Though K. Tracy (1995) does not explicitly identify AIDA as social construction research, in its ability to connect the discursive construction of problems to the situated ideals of participants and especially in its way of proposing new grammars of practice, we consider AIDA to be a practical social construction theory.

Dialogic Approaches

As "one key concept that helped…scholars guide their research with more constructionist epistemologies" (R. Anderson, Baxter, & Cissna, 2004, p. 10), *dialogue* appears as both philosophical idea and practical theory in CSC. Dialogic perspectives can be descriptive or prescriptive (Stewart, Zediker, & Black, 2004). Stewart et al. characterized "all human life" as dialogical (p. 21). In prescriptive approaches, such as that described by Buber (1970), the term *dialogue* refers to a unique circumstance of connections between people. In addition to providing basic background information on dialogue, we examine dialogic approaches that address constructionist concerns: McNamee and Gergen's (1999) conception of relational responsibility, Baxter and Montgomery's (1996) relational dialectics, and practical, community applications of dialogue. Each of these perspectives addresses the dialogical

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nature of communication and social constructionist concerns of practicality of theory, the consequential and constitutive nature of communication, and the relational nature of knowledge.

R. Anderson et al. (2004) noted that "readers surveying the historical literature on dialogue within communication (in interpersonal communication, rhetoric, and media studies especially) encounter four names with regularity: Buber, Gadamer, Habermas, and Bakhtin" (p. 3). Collectively, these authors contribute the following ideas to our understanding of dialogue. Dialogue, as an ideal, constitutes a relational process in which self and other (I-thou) are interconnected and both altered in the process of dialogue (Buber, 1970; Gadamer, 1975). As Wood (2004) explained, dialogue "means that interlocutors are immersed in a process that shapes and forms them even as they shape and form it and one another in ways that are not entirely predictable or finalizable" (p. xvii). Habermas (1984) stressed the interconnection between situation or public context and conditions that facilitate dialogue. The work of Russian literary scholar Bakhtin (1981, 1984) emphasized the "multivocal" nature of social life. Theorizing about dialogue also involves theorizing about the socially constructed nature of self and the social world (see also Lucaites & Fitch, 1997).

Cissna and R. Anderson's (1998) analysis of the transcribed conversation between therapist Carl Rogers and Martin Buber offers a way to bridge notions of dialogue as ideal and as situated relational knowing by means of the concept of dialogic moments—"both a quality of relationships, that arises, however briefly, between two or more people and [also] a way of thinking about human affairs that highlights their dialogic quality" (p. 64). According to Cissna and R. Anderson, dialogic moments occur when structural inequalities (presumed by the helping relationship of therapy) or asymmetry between I and Thou do not matter. They asserted that moments of dialogue permit the creative connections whereby dialogic partners "turn toward the other and both mutually perceive the impact of each other's turning" (p. 74).[5]

Criticizing traditional notions of responsibility that locate blame and deviance at the individual level, McNamee and Gergen (1999) argued for a perspective of responsibility as relational in which the "joint-action" of social actors is featured in considering responsibility. Responsibility in relationships, then, involves "… a dialogic process with two transformative functions: first, in transforming the interlocutors' understanding of the action in question (the fault, failing, crime, etc.) and second, in altering the relations among the interlocutors themselves" (p. 5). The concept of relational responsibility provides a re-conceptualization of a significant concept (responsibility) through a social constructionist lens.

Baxter and Montgomery's (1996) theory of relational dialectics underscored the contradictory tensions present in interpersonal relationships. Using an analogy with the concept of the yin and the yang from Chinese culture, Baxter and Montgomery asserted that these contradictions are not

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necessarily undesirable aspects of relationships but, rather, inherent in relationships. Examples of relational contradictions include the competing desires to be autonomous yet connected to another, to maintain privacy and share, and to experience certainty and surprise. Each of these dialectics may operate in terms of how self and relational partner interact, or how a relational grouping (i.e., the couple as a unit) interacts with outsiders. Relational dialectics focuses on the constitutive role of communication in constructing relationship; drawing heavily from Bakhtin's (1981) idea of polyphony, it also calls attention to the multiplicity of voices involved in constructing social relationships.

Building bridges both within the discipline and into practical theory, the approach of dialogue has combined assumptions from the coordinated management of meaning theory to open up a new space for interaction in communities (e.g., Dillon & Galanes, 2002; K. A. Pearce & W. B. Pearce, 2001; W. B. Pearce & K. A. Pearce, 2000; Spano, 2001). Endeavors such as the *Public Conversations Project* (Family Institute of Cambridge, MA) have taken dialogue as practical theory to the public arena, where shifts in modes of accounting affect relationships between people who disagreed strongly on issues of public significance, such as abortion, the Israeli–Palestian crisis, or the events of September 11, 2001 (Herzig & Chasin, 2006). Though they did not necessarily achieve agreement, they co-constructed a new awareness of the others' accounts as a possibility to coexist as long as the conversation continues. This idea of a continuing conversation reflects Bakhtin's (1986) notion of dialogue as infinite process, or indeed, as a ripple effect of relational configurations that transcend the self-other dyad to create a conversational multilogue, or polyphony. H. Anderson (1997) summarized that "each conversation is embedded within and will become a part of, will be influenced by and will influence myriad other past and future conversations" (p. 111).

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Summary

We have identified several ways in which social constructionist ideas have been applied in communication. First, we noted how communication scholars use different terms (i.e., *interpretive*, *social*, *constitutive*) to articulate a social constructionist stance. Second, we outlined a sample of communication approaches that apply social constructionist assumptions. In identifying them, we called attention to specific ways in which communication scholars have developed social constructionist perspectives. In analyzing SC in communication research, we have identified it as embodied (e.g., Bruss et al., 2005; Cronen, 1995a; Shailor, 1994; Shotter & Katz, 1998), practical and grounded (e.g., Holman & Thorpe, 2003; Castor, 2005; Craig & K. Tracy, 1995), ontologically oriented (e.g., Deetz, 1994; W. B. Pearce & K. A. Pearce, 2000; Stewart, 1995; Tracy & Baratz, 1993), and experiential in terms of real phenomena in our everyday life (Edley, 2001).

PRACTICING SOCIAL CONSTRUCTION IN GENDER, CRISIS, AND THERAPY: ADDRESSING MATERIALITY, AGENCY, AND CONSEQUENTIALITY

In this section, we strive to take our presentation further and address one (as yet unresolved) misunderstanding both within and without social construction—which equates an SC view as relativist and offers realism as its alternative (see Burr, 2003; Edley, 2001; Edwards et al., 1995; Gergen, 2001; Shotter & Lannamann, 2002, for voices within the debate)—and show how practical applications of it have allowed stepping outside this knot. As social constructionists, Shotter and Lannamann, as well as Burr, recognized that SC has gradually become a source of disenchantment if not "personal paralysis" (Burr, p. 14). Shotter and Lannamann also observed how the epistemologically elegant ritual of theory, criticism, and debate in social constructionist discussions fail to engage the messy, embodied, and accountable ontology of living beings.

More specifically, Burr (2003) found that the construct of agency put forth by SC indicates no more than "an effect of discourse" that pulls "the rug… out under our feet" (p. 14), leaving no notion of the choosing person intact. A second problematic deals with SC's limitations in matters of materiality (Lannamann, 1998). Ultimately, this dilemma grapples with how social constructionists account for the physical world without denying it through a strict relativist argument or subordinating their own position to a realist and representational rather than constitutive notion. Finally, social constructionists have had to address the belief that social action (or change, or oppression, or liberation) happens outside of discourse. We refer to this belief as an *issue of consequentiality*.

We borrow Gergen's (1998) Wittgensteinian question and "go on" to offer a contribution to SC dilemmas from communication practice. We focus our review now on CSC research in the three topic areas of gender, crisis, and therapy. These three research areas address the limitations identified by SC critics and supporters in matters of materiality, agency, and consequentiality. Research on gender highlights issues of identity, agency, and materiality by describing the different ways in which people construct identity in light of various circumstances. We also concentrate on two areas of practice. By selecting crisis and therapy, we consider the concerns of practitioners in everyday life situations who apply the propositions of CSC to make decisions with long-lasting consequences in the lives of others. Especially with the situation of crisis, we illustrate that SC can speak meaningfully on the issue of material circumstances. Crises are as real in material terms as they are in the visceral reaction of seeing death; both crises and therapy can be productively understood by means of a SC perspective.

Our choice of three topic areas is strategic because gender, crisis, and therapy provide ways to understand differences across cultures, nations,

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and socioeconomic circumstances. We hope that our three areas of focus allow readers to imagine building conversational connections between social constructionist work that pushes boundaries not only across practices but across national communities, recognizing SC's potential to reconstitute conversations in the many embodied responses of scholars and practitioners internationally.

Social Construction and Gender: Re-constituting Identity and Materiality

"All feminist theory since Simone de Beauvoir ('one is not born but becomes a woman')," argued Cameron (2005), "could aptly be described as 'social constructionist': the whole concept of gender, as distinct from sex, is inherently social constructionist" (pp. 332-333). By locating gender in the dynamic of interaction and in the accomplishments of performance, a CSC approach illustrates how identity is not pre-set but a matter of discursively constructed physical presence. While gender and communication research has traditionally focused on women's experiences and the construction of female identity, more recent work has called attention to the construction of masculine identity (e.g., Ashcraft & Mumby, 2004b; Dow & Condit, 2005) as well as transgendered identity (Papoulias, 2006).

We must distinguish between "second wave" and "third wave" approaches. Cameron (2005) characterized second wave as a modernist or essentialist approach that treats gender as a stable and binary category that focuses on differences of communication between males and females. Studies that describe gender in terms of "dominance" or "difference" fall within this category in that these terms imply an "essentialist" assumption regarding gender. The third wave approach, as explained by Cameron, comprises a postmodernist or social constructionist approach that examines gender as performed (Butler, 1990)[6] and locally enacted through communication. However, notably, the third wave can be divided even further into two main categories: interaction-focused and poststructuralist.

Interaction-focused studies draw from traditions such as symbolic interactionism, Goffman's (1959) dramaturgical perspective, Garfinkel's (1967) ethnomethodological approach, conversation analysis (e.g., Sacks, 1995), and sociolinguistics (e.g., Gumperz, 1982). Poststructuralist projects draw from philosophers of language (Bakhtin, 1981, 1984, 1986; Vygotsky, 1986) and critical theorists such as, most notably, Foucault (1980). Both approaches assume that gender encompasses a social practice, constituted in and through interactions and discursive constructions. However, differences exist in the type of research conducted under the umbrella of each approach.

Among interaction-oriented approaches, two key perspectives include ethnomethodology (e.g., Hansen, 2006; Papoulias, 2006; see also Garfinkel, 1967, for his classic analysis of Agnes) and narrative (i.e., Gubrium, 2006). Interaction-oriented approaches may also focus on various levels of discourse.

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For example, Guerin (1994) examined gender bias at the level of verbs and adjectives. Stapleton (2003) described the practice of swearing and its interrelationship with gender. Madsen (2003) analyzed the negotiation of power among bilingual Turkish-Danish children. Addressing the interrelationship between power and everyday language practices, Kitzinger (2005) and Land and Kitzinger (2005) studied the discursive display of heterosexual and homosexual identity. Schiffrin (1996) explored the use of narrative by Jewish American women to exercise agency and construct identity. In a similar project, Gubrium detailed the use of narrative by African American women to construct their own "American Dream" story as a form of empowerment. As Gubrium explained, her main interviewee "talked herself into being" (p. 231) through the stories she told about her life. Pienaar and Bekker (2006) applied critical discourse analysis and Butler's theory of performance to explain how young South African women constructed and performed notions of an ideal feminine physique in their everyday conversations. Using an ethnographic approach, Hansen focused on the interconnection between gender and dance in constructing Mexican identity. Hansen's study highlighted communication in the form of personal address and reference terms as well as costuming and accessories, thus including both the discursive and material in his analysis.

Gender CSC researchers have considered the interconnection between communication and materiality in other ways as well. Brush (1997), using historical data starting from the 1900s, described how "expert talk" constructs single mother identity and the implications of those constructions for social policy. Ryan (1994) focused on space, city life, social class, and gendered identities. Literally addressing the body, Papoulias (2006) provided a conceptual piece on transgendered identity:

> Transgender is one of the latest in a series of terms which, in the social sciences, have sought to name counter-normative materializations of gender on individual bodies, through practices of gender-crossing either in matters of dress and presentation, and/or in terms of body modification. (p. 231)

As mentioned earlier, increasingly, scholars attend to the construction of masculine identities. Meân (2001) concentrated on sports and how the discourse of male football referees constructs gendered (both male and female) identities. Harter (2004) examined masculine identity and the agrarian frontier in a cooperative organization.

A growing number of organizational communication scholars draw from postmodern and poststructuralist traditions (e.g., Ashcraft & Mumby, 2004a; Buzzanell & Liu, 2005). Buzzanell (1995) explicitly took a social constructionist perspective in her analysis of the glass ceiling. Trethewey (2000) detailed how communication constitutes organizations through culture and embodied identity. Interactionist and poststructuralist do not encompass

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all of the approaches; others include sense-making (Buzzanell et al., 2005), communities of practice (Stapleton, 2003), and critical legal theory (Hasian, 2004). Scholars use Butler's gender as performance work as a primary basis for theoretical framing (Pienaar & Bekker, 2006) and in gender and communication research (e.g., Bell & Blaeuer, 2006). Also, some scholars have begun to develop uniquely communication approaches that theorize about gender (Ashcraft & Mumby, 2004a, 2004b; see also Harter, 2004) Ashcraft and Mumby, in particular, developed a feminist communicology of organization that argues for the interconnection of the SC of gendered identity and organizations. Ashcraft and Mumby's project also explicitly featured the discursive construction of identity, power, resistance, history, and materiality.

Several gender and communication scholars have stressed the contradiction and irony in the construction of gendered identities. For example, Harter (2004) highlighted the incongruities involved with constructions of gender in her organizational site with the typically feminine notion of cooperation being connected to masculine notions of the frontier. Buzzanell and Liu (2005) analyzed the inconsistencies involved with maternity leave policies. S. J. Tracy and Trethewey (2005) provided a very insightful argument for re-conceptualizing the organizational self in terms of a "crystallized" identity. Critiquing popular and scholarly research that discusses "fake selves" and "real selves," S. J. Tracy and Trethewey noted that such a dichotomy serves the managerial interests of the organization. In contrast, "[t]he crystallized self is multidimensional--the more facets, the more beautiful and complex… .crystallized selves have different shapes depending on the various discourses through which they are constructed and constrained" (p. 186). S. J. Tracy and Trethewey recognized that identity is socially constructed; in their proposal, they emphasized agency by advocating a change in how organizational members, popular writers, and organizational scholars conceptualize organizational identities. Refracted through a social constructionist lens, researchers position gender in communication in terms of the discursive construction of identity, where communication both enables and constrains identity and always responds to social and material circumstances.

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Crisis: The Consequentiality of Social Construction

Crisis, argued Edelman (1974), is nothing if not a discursive construction that serves the political aims of those who can benefit from events being enacted as crisis (see also Altheide, 2001). Envisioning a disaster such as Hurricane Katrina or the Southeast Asian tsunami as a crisis involves considering the consequentiality of certain discursive constructions by particular people in certain ways on the lives of impacted individuals (see related discussion on trauma by Grey, 2007). Notions of risk, vulnerability, preparedness, and nature itself are all forms of accounting that coordinate action in crisis situations, making the difference between life and death. Stallings (1990, p. 92) noted that "[r]isk is not the *outcome* of media and public discourse, but exists *in and*

through processes of discourse. Hence, risk is never constant. It is created and recreated in discussion of events that are seen to undermine a world taken for granted."

We proceed from an overview of problems as social constructions to discussing the significance of understanding social problems and natural disaster crises in social constructionist terms.

Schön (1983) argued that problems are not described, but rather "set." He explained that "problem setting is a process in which, interactively, we *name* the things to which we will attend and *frame* the context in which we will attend to them" (p. 40). In this view, problems are not 'givens' but, instead, constructed as such through communication. Buttny (2004) provided a very explicit discussion of the social (discursive) construction of problems in various contexts, including therapy discussions (see also Buttny, 1996) and campus discussions of race. K. Tracy's work also addressed the construction of problems in areas such as school board meetings (K. Tracy & Muller, 2001) and emergency service requests (K. Tracy, 1997). Castor (2007) described the construction of problems in school board meetings as well as during a university budget crisis (Castor & Cooren, 2006). Collectively, these projects illustrate how various discursive practices such as reported speech (Buttny, 1996, 2004), problem formulation (Tracy), metacommunication (Castor), and accounting (Castor & Cooren) function to define and construct what counts as a problem and the consequences of those definitions to the actors involved.

Studies on the SC of crises have usefully drawn from examinations of social problems (Best, 1995; Spector & Kitsuse, 1977) to highlight the role of the media in the discursive construction of problem accounts. For example, Altheide (2001) argued in the title of his book that the media constructs crisis by "creating fear." Abu-Laban and Garber (2005) and Greenberg and Hier (2001) each detailed the SC of immigrants and refugees as social problems in Canada by using textual analyses of newspapers. Mazzarella and Pecora (2007) described the construction of "girls in crisis," and, also considering the construction of youth, Staller (2003) focused on runaways in the U.S. media in the 1960s and 1970s. Pride (1999) pursued the construction of race in the south. Finally, exploring a global context, Tacke (2001) addressed the SC of BSE (mad cow disease) as a problem.

In a recent online interdisciplinary forum on Hurricane Katrina, anthropologists, environmentalists, management, and geography experts among others discussed how disasters constitute *un*natural phenomena (Smith, 2006), dictated by social forces as much as by nature. Tracing the shift between constructs of preparedness and vulnerability in knowledge about disaster, Bankoff (2006) argued that the latter seemed to provide a notion of embodied first person as opposed to the third person scientific knowledge of the former. Vulnerability evokes the relative position of a body to another and the image of how a body might be left behind. However, the way in which the particular form of accounting materialized revealed very different stakes at work for

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those so categorized. Bodies considered "vulnerable" were isolated from those considered safe, with help transferred to the safe zone and the "vulnerable" zone declared "unsafe." This practice, as Bankoff concluded, revealed that vulnerability and preparedness, while seemingly different at the level of representation, practically materialized as flip sides of the same coin. As Smith observed, a similar fate seems destined to the account of "reconstruction" offered to the zone hit by the Indian Ocean tsunami, where the rebuilding project privileges oceanfront wealth.

These studies of crisis from CSC perspectives illustrate the discursive accomplishment of problems. Of course, events such as immigration, hurricanes, and the like are not exclusively forms of discourse, but their meanings and treatment as "problems" or "crises" mark a communicative achievement. Significantly, whether and what kind of action is taken as follow-up depends on how stakeholders construct them as such.

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Reconstituting Therapy: From Narrative to Performance, from Representation to Action

In its manifestations of Fred Newman's social therapy, narrative therapy, and dialogical therapy, social constructionist constitutions of therapy reflect discursive *differences that make a difference* (Bateson, 1972); they continue to add significance to the embeddedness of mind in communication established by Bateson and the Palo Alto Group (e.g., Watzlawick, Bavelas, & Jackson, 1967).

Lannamann (1998) cautioned against the danger of an immaterial, abstract version of SC in therapeutic practice:

> [A] social constructionist approach [should]…be *a political approach*, not in the sense of imposing a particular arrangement of authority, but rather in the sense of identifying the material practices in which certain forms of relational embodiment are enabled while others are constrained (emphasis added). (p. 411)

In presenting the following examples, we believe that applications of forms of SC in therapeutic practice constitute political acts of discursive re-embodiment, reconfiguring relationships, experiences of the material world, past constraints, and future enablements. The work of philosopher Fred Newman and psychologist Lois Holzman at the East Side Center for Social Therapy in New York City makes a crucial political distinction between "power" and "authority" (Holzman, 2004). Whereas authority, as Lannamann (1998) described it, is imposed by individuals (authors) in the form of knowledge, power comprises the bottom-up activity by stakeholders able to creatively resist it. One form of creative resistance to authority involves the refusal to adopt the knowledge of specialized vocabulary of expert description (Newman, 1991). Working within a Marxist awareness on myths as social

control and Vygotsky's perspective about enacting social change in everyday settings, Newman and Holzman attack the social potential of diagnosis and other forms of expert mythology—addiction, deviancy, panic, depression—that maintain the authority of psychiatric nomenclature. In its place, they practice community therapy, which is actually not therapy in the traditional sense at all but the overseeing of open-ended group performances organized around therapeutic themes and terms. By recontextualizing an expert practice such as diagnosing into "a radically democratic, performatory environment" (Holzman, 1999, p. 85), Newman seeks to "create new forms of life" by exploiting gaps in Wittgensteinian language games. Newman aims to demystify psychological classification and authority and to move toward a collaborative, participatory, and truly embodied practice of psychology.

In the United Kingdom, practitioners employ both social constructionist and narrative therapies of White and Epston (1990) politically to serve clients in the lesbian, gay, bisexual, and queer community (www.thepinkpractice.com.uk). Paying attention to how the stories that we tell about ourselves trap us into cultural and relational plots that hurt us, practitioners at The Pink Practice apply the ideas of White and Epston to challenge assumptions about pathology, sexuality, gender, and life choices. They replace stories of oppression with ones of possibility. As Lotringer said, one does not cure neurosis; one changes a society which cannot do without it (as cited in Holtzman, 1999, p. 83).

No less political is the material change affected by Norwegian therapist Tom Andersen (1990) by introducing the practice of the reflecting team to family therapy. Traditionally, the one-way mirror divided therapist and family (Hoffman, 2001) so as to permit two kinds of observation and two kinds of accounting: the first in the moment, by the therapist in the room with the family; the second, detached, by the therapists of the team hidden behind the looking glass, always informing the first. A hierarchical construction of knowledge would, therefore, be set up between levels of therapist accounting and family accounts (Bartesaghi, 2004). By tearing down the reflecting barrier between the first-person knowledge of the family's experience and the third-person theoretical assumptions of the therapist, Tom Andersen's approach works by allowing the two kinds of accounting to continuously feed into each other, rejecting the secrecy of therapeutic strategy in favor of an accountable exchange between viewpoints (see discussion by H. Anderson, 1997). This strategy makes room for a third kind of knowing, collaborative and emergent in the between. Katz and Shotter (1996) noted how Andersen makes connections in the moment during a session of therapy that a client finds striking, arresting, moving.

Therapy entails communication that is constitutive and consequential; a client's reality can shift dramatically in the course of a fifty-minute session, reconstructing versions of past, present, and possible future. A therapist can create this shift through strategic questioning. Questions comprise powerful

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discursive resources. In everyday conversation, they both open and constrain a space for the other's answer (Wang, 2006); in therapy, they intervene in the client's world by forcing a common ground with the therapist's presuppositions (McGee, Del Vento, & Beavin Bavelas, 2005). "Every time we ask a question," remarked narrative therapist David Epston, "we're generating a possible version of a life" (in Freedman & Combs, 1996, p. 113). Constructionist therapists Freedman and Combs generate new experience for their clients by opening up a space for accounting that defies problems, even in the midst of problematic life accounts. For instance, the therapist(s) might ask, "You've said that, even though moods of hopelessness often lead you to suicidal thoughts, you know that you don't really want to die. When was the last time this knowledge helped you turn suicidal thoughts away?" (p. 101).

Alternatively, the therapist(s) may show the client how to "go on" by inviting them to step into someone else's accounting position, by asking such questions as "Can you understand how from my point of view you are ready to take on this responsibility? What do you think I've noticed that makes me think so?" (Freedman & Combs, 1996, p. 127). We see these questions pushing for SC as a practice that is, as Keillor (1987) suggested, "not for the timid" (p. xv).

Harlene Anderson[7] posed a stern counter-proposition to the traditional assumption of the therapist's ability to exert authority through theoretical, non-conversationally generated knowledge. Rejecting all notions of strategy and intervention as unproductive for therapeutic conversation as a joint process between therapist and client, H. Anderson (1997) proposed that the therapist approach interaction from a perspective of *not knowing*. What the therapist should not know, and should try to prevent herself from knowing, encompasses anything for which she cannot be directly accountable to the client from within the conversation. Thus, according to H. Anderson, they should reject common practices such as reading the client's record prior to a session, being aware of a patient's diagnosis, or all ideas pertaining to manuals and phases of the session because the therapist is inside, and not outside, the process (she) is trying to create. Drawing on the idea of dialogue as reciprocal, accountable interaction between multiple voices elaborated by Bakhtin (1981, 1984, 1986), H. Anderson described the not-knowing stance as one of freedom. Once the therapist is liberated from the ideological bind to control the conversation and the trappings (and potential entrapments) of authority, s/he clears space for creativity, trust, and problems to be resolved through the emergence of a new way of telling the story of self.

However, how much can a dialogical therapist truly be free from the hierarchal demands of power and still be a therapist (Guilfoyle, 2003)? The question belies a view of communication as strategy and of authority (or power) as, once again, something outside of it (H. Anderson, 2005). According to H. Anderson, the answer, as social construction in its therapeutic applications suggests, lies in taking communication as practical theory and therapy as a conversation of "everyday life" (p. 503), rife with ambiguity, difficult questions,

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shifting asymmetries, and moments of connection (or not), that can, at best, be addressed as life in conversation.

Summary

In reviewing CSC research in gender, crisis, and therapy, we highlighted the specific ways in which communication researchers have applied an SC perspective. As we stated earlier, our choice of topical areas was strategic in that these topics address key issues and dilemmas in SC research such as identity, agency, materiality, and power.

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FUTURE DIRECTIONS: WHERETO THE CONVERSATION?

In rejoining Shotter and Gergen's (1994) contribution to *Communication Yearbook*, we wished to explore the place of SC research in communication. The variety of theories that attribute their development to SC and practical research in areas such as gender, crisis, and therapy point to the significant interrelationship between communication and SC. While this theorizing and research is promising, we advance specific future issues and directions for CSC research.

The Role of Criticism and Contemporary Social and Political Issues

A central premise of SC, we believe, is to raise questions about tacit knowledge (Burr, 2003; Gergen, 1999; see also related discussion by Garfinkel, 1967, regarding the taken-for-granted in ethnomethodology). As such, we conceive of SC as a critical position, for when stakeholders make visible taken-for-granted assumptions and perspectives, they can realize that previously accepted orientations "could have been different—and, in taking something for granted, we forget that it could have been different" (Phillips & Jørgensen, 2002, pp. 185-186). Contemporary issues (such as terrorism, the growing disparity between the rich and the poor, lack of adequate health care, genocide with the accompanying systematic raping of women, and civil wars with children soldiers) constitute circumstances that "could" and *should* be different. SC researchers are well-poised to interrogate how participants discursively co-construct these situations and to explore alternatives.

On May 26, 2004, editors of the *New York Times*, including Howell Raines and Gerald Boyd, published an apology for the newspaper's sloppy coverage of the events leading up to the Iraq war prior to Raines' and Boyd's resignations (see Mnookin, 2004). The editors cited numerous examples in which the paper as a whole (reporters and editors) failed to question constructions of the

situation in Iraq presented by various officials and their sources. Perhaps the most significant evidence dealt with Saddam Hussein's capacity to develop nuclear weapons and the controversy of the "aluminum tubes" as evidence for that capacity. As the *New York Times* editors explained, "There were hints that the usefulness of the tubes in making nuclear fuel was not a sure thing, but the hints were buried deep, 1,700 words into a 3,600-word article. Administration officials were allowed to hold forth at length on why this evidence of Iraq's nuclear intentions demanded that Saddam Hussein be dislodged from power" (p. 2). The editorial letter from the *New York Times* illustrates the need to ask questions. In retrospect, the editors recognized their own taken-for-granted assumptions (see also Arsenault & Castells, 2006).

Estimates suggest that hundreds of thousands of people have been killed in the Darfur region of the Sudan over the past few years ("Hundreds Killed in Attacks in Eastern Chad," 2007). This situation has been constructed in diverse ways, from a need for humanitarian efforts to a crisis, genocide, and ethnic cleansing; each account leads to a different consequence in terms of action. In September, 2004, U.S. President George Bush declared the situation "genocide" and authorized aid to the region (Bush, 2004). However, the United Nations, while providing support, has declined to label the situation genocide ("Report of the International Commission of Inquiry on Darfur to the United Nations Secretary-General," 2005). About this matter, Reeves (2006) explained:

> [N]one of this would be more than a debate about nomenclature if a finding of genocide did not hold the potential to dictate the need for humanitarian intervention in Darfur … Genocide should not, of course, be the threshold for humanitarian intervention; but in the world as we find it, in the wake of genocides in the Balkans and Rwanda, the g-word has come increasingly to constitute a ghastly gold standard for international action. (¶ 37)

A social constructionist position does not deny dead bodies. However, a CSC position (which we have captured here as it is articulated in its theoretical universe as practical, consequential, and constitutive) would interrogate the discursive constructions, the consequences of those constructions, the alternatives, and the entailments of future responses.

Conceptual Issues

For CSC to be relevant and practical, social constructionists must engage the interrelationship between *d*iscourse and *D*iscourse, or communication and what is now largely (mis)understood as residing in the universe of the extra-discursive: power and agency, respectively (Burr, 2003; Lannamann, 1998; Phillips & Jørgensen, 2002). This perceived split between what social construction can offer and the (realities of the) material world is born from a pragmatic, representational, and purely epistemological version of SC (Gergen,

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1992, 1994, 1998, 2001) that sets aside ontological matters for the purpose of selecting among available forms of communication. However, practical communication choices cannot be performed from ontological disengagement but only from within the moral and social constraints that allow them and the consequences that will follow (Held, 2002). When thinking in terms of our responsibility and of the consequences with respect to our decisions, choices, and actions within the larger political and social frame, it is impossible to extricate discourse and Discourse. To avoid the potential paralysis of an "ontologically mute" (Gergen, 1992, p. 171) social constructionism, we should attend to the concerns of the material world in our discursive reconstitution of SC. Though CSC researchers have dealt with the (so-called) extra-discursive (i.e., in studies of gender and crisis), the extra-discursive needs to be more thoroughly and explicitly addressed as consequential and inextricable from the discursive so that we may break out of—rather than avoid or circumvent—arguments that begin with furniture thumping and lead us nowhere.

Alvesson and Karreman (2000) described four "levels" of discourse that, for the sake of simplicity, we collapse into the categories of "discourse" (with a lower-case *d*) and "Discourse" (with an upper-case *D*). The former refers to language use in specific contexts or micro-practices. The latter refers to enduring patterns across contexts. Variations exist in terms of how communication social constructionists address *d*iscourse and *D*iscourse. Those of us with roots in ethnography, ethnomethodology, and other language and social interaction approaches (Fitch & Sanders, 2005) tend to focus on discourse. As Alvesson and Karreman observed, social construction researchers who emphasize poststructural analysis tend to concentrate on *D*iscourse, viewing data as a manifestation of broader systems or patterns. One conceptual issue that communication social constructionists need to address involves finding ways to make our theoretical accounts of the world relevant both in *d*iscourse and *D*iscourse, bridging micro- and macro-universes of analysis; in so doing, communication theories will critically reflect on the material reality of those theorized about and, as a result, constituted in its practical applications (Krippendorff, 1996, 1997; Parker, 1999). This issue is considered to a degree through the study of accounting and social accountability (e.g., Buttny, 1993, 1996, 2004; Shotter, 1984). Organizational communication scholars, in particular, have done a thorough job of showing the problematics involved with interrelating discourse and *D*iscourse (e.g., Cooren & Fairhurst, in press; Dixon, 2000; Fairhurst & Putnam, 2004).

Notions of power and agency warrant additional attention from a CSC perspective. By constituting communication as an ontological discipline that makes a difference in practice, social constructionist scholarship cannot eschew political considerations in its research and applications (Lannamann, 1998; Phillips & Jørgensen, 2002). It cannot, for example, abstain from addressing power by arguing that making claims regarding power privileges one position (usually, the researchers') over others, as if such a practice comprised an

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avoidable (or undesirable) condition of doing research. Nor can researchers or practitioners within an SC communication tradition presume that power exists "outside of" our SCs, as institutions or abstract social structures.

The work of Foucault (1980), among other theorists examining the role of language as a form of social and institutional power (e.g., Bakhtin, 1981, 1986; Habermas, 1984; Volosinov, 1986), is largely credited for illuminating the social consequentiality of communication. Ironically, however, Foucault's work abstracted power rather than materialized it because he did not offer a clear conceptual map to locate power within the embodied communication of relationships (Thornborrow, 2002). Foucaultian power, being everywhere, is (for practical purposes) nowhere at all (Krippendorff, 1995) and remains empirically unavailable.

In communication, scholars of language and social interaction (Fitch & Sanders, 2005) have grounded a notion of discursive power in everyday discourse, linking interaction with the broader social and institutional framework that enables and constrains it, thus showing how power is empirically accessible and visibly co-constructed in the constantly shifting asymmetry of moment-to-moment conversational relationships. An example of how power is made visible as embodied communication is the study of questioning by various scholars in both conversation and discourse analysis across various institutional settings. Sacks (1995) noted that asking questions within a conversation constitutes a powerful discursive act (see also Wang, 2006, for an overview of questioning research) that delineates different rights and obligations for participants in an exchange. Further, Mehan (1996) detailed how the definition of a student as learning disabled results from a decision-making process that not all involved parties can dispute or understand. Power, argued Mehan (1990, 1996), entails the ability of some to define the reality of others by deciding on the meaning of a situation; asking questions is a powerful way to define reality within an institution.

If questions constitute powerful discursive resources, the study of questioning practices illuminates the difference between those who are able to use the resource for their advantage and those who cannot and interrogates the material consequences of such difference. Zimmerman's (1992) as well and K. Tracy's (K. Tracy, 1997; K. Tracy & S. J. Tracy, 1998) research on 911 emergency call centers examines the co-construction of problems between callers and dispatchers, which can make the difference between getting and not getting help. Hutchby (2002) examined how a child in counseling responds to the therapist's questioning in a baffling and noncooperative way (according to the therapist!), somewhat upsetting the therapeutic asymmetry and causing the therapist to seek novel discursive strategies.

Thornborrow's (2002) analysis of institutional talk offers another example of how CSC can address power by making it visible in processes of co-construction. By blending conversation analysis and critical discourse analysis, Thornborrow specified how members structurally accomplish

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institutions through the everyday orderliness of conversational turn-taking, while all the time leaving cracks open at the level of conversational order for upheavals in structure to occur. Empirical work such as Thornborrow's demystifies the notion of power as everywhere, or even structural and invisible, (Krippendorff, 1995), citing its material consequences in the dynamics of communication.

The issue of agency encompasses another problematic for SC researchers. A traditional notion of agency objectifies this construct as a property of the individual, in that individuals make choices, have responsibility, and can be blamed. However, this notion over-presumes the role of an individual in an interaction (see McNamee & Gergen, 1999). An alternative conception of agency as relational is more consistent with SC research (see Robichaud, 2005). In the notion of agency as relational, one's agency is established or based in relationship with others, as we position ourselves as the "I," as actors in our own self-discourse (Harré, 1999). In conversation, others grant us agency by validating our first-person constructions. In turn, a relationally situated agency calls for a moral notion of self (Lewis, 2003) as a co-constituted account that we claim, and others can deny or validate, in everyday negotiations of the self. What the self can or should be or what it can accomplish as agent is situated in the discursive accomplishments of our speech acts, accounts, and narratives (e.g., Potter & Wetherell, 1987).

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CONCLUSION

In his response to their proposal for social construction as a framework for communication, W. B. Pearce (1994) critiqued Shotter and Gergen (1994) for not being sufficiently radical and instead identifying propositions of SC grounded in psychology conversations, best suited for a critique of Enlightenment thinking. We agree with W. B. Pearce's sentiment and assert that communication has a greater role to play in constructing SC than that originally put forth by Shotter and Gergen.

In re-constituting SC in this chapter, we provided a different starting point for discussing SC from a communication perspective. We described the metadiscursive vocabulary in use by researchers who do social constructionist research; these terms include *interpretive research, social approaches, constitutive perspective*, and *construction* with various modifiers. The existence of this vocabulary indicates a great deal of SC research in communication, but this research may not be easily identified under the *nom de plume* of "social construction." Our review also identified a selection of approaches in communication that reflects a social constructionist orientation. These approaches illustrate how communication scholars have made unique contributions to understanding SC. In highlighting research on gender, crisis, and therapy, we selected topics of relevance for researchers and practitioners.

Our selected topic areas illustrated how SC research in communication has fruitfully engaged a dialogue within challenging conceptual areas such as identity, agency, and materiality in the tug-of-war of two monological dead ends represented by relativism on the one hand and realism on the other.

While research and theorizing in CSC have been promising, additional issues and future directions should be considered by CSC researchers to increase relevance to the discipline and to practitioners. First, CSC researchers should deal with social and political issues. CSC researchers have a unique voice to lend in examining how certain circumstances came to be as part of a communication process. A next step from a social constructionist perspective involves further interrogating how things could be otherwise.

At a more general, conceptual level, CSC researchers should address issues of (what is now perceived as) the extra-discursive: power and agency. These topics pose particular challenges to SC researchers, and they have been discussed and debated in other fields such as psychology and sociology. Despite some discussion (notably, in the area of organizational communication), we feel that CSC as an enterprise can develop more sophisticated ways of conceptualizing and researching communication through further dialogue on these issues.

* * *

It is impossible for us to imagine a conversation about communication without the ideas, tensions, or possibilities set forth by SC. At the conclusion of our contribution, we are humbled to have created an opportunity for the conversation to continue.

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NOTES

1. We wish to note this chapter is not unique in providing a review of communication social constructionist work (e.g., Allen, 2005; W. B. Pearce, 1992, 1994). Leeds-Hurwitz (forthcoming), which covers SC research in the last decade, is the most recent project that provides an extensive analysis of social construction research in communication. Other relevant reviews include Wicks' (2005) review of constructionism in mass communication framing research, and the Jackson, Poole, and Kuhn's (2002) review of the social construction of technology in the workplace. As we write this chapter, another forthcoming work deserves notice as a marker that SC is alive and well as a framework in the social sciences: *The Handbook of Social Constructionist Research*, edited by Holstein & Gubrium (2007).

2. Acknowledging that our review is not exhaustive, we also note what we did not include, namely, rhetorical perspectives (Billig, 1987; Potter, 1996) and technological perspectives (Dayton, 2006; Fulk, 1993; Jackson et al., 2002).
3. For a more thorough discussion of research in CMM, we recommend Barge & W. B. Pearce (2004).
4. Shotter has used various terms for his work including a "rhetorical-responsive version of social constructionism" (1993, p. 1), a "dialogical-relational-responsive form of practical understanding" (1998, p. 140), "expressive responsive" (2004, p. 205), and "relationally-responsive" (2006, p. 590). We utilize the phrasing *relationally responsive* in accordance to Shotter's most recent choice.
5. This notion of mutual impact in dialogue resembles Shotter's (2000b) description of knowing of the third kind and Lannamann's (1998) idea of presence.
6. Some scholars described Butler's work as social constructionist; whereas, others (e.g., Bell & Blaeuer, 2006) characterized Butler's work as distinct from social constructionism.
7. A close collaborator of the late Harold Goolishian (see, e.g., Anderson & Goolishian, 1988, 1992; Goolishian & Anderson, 2002).

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